

expressed their opinions fearlessly, no matter how unpopular those opinions might have been. The voice of dissent has died away to a barely audible whisper. Present-day specimens of the vanishing breed are generally timorous and emasculated parodies akin to the medieval pedants who debated the question of how many angels could dance on the head of a pin.

Today's dissenters mainly focus their attention and expend their energies on the most inconsequential of trivia.

Where the Ida Tarbells and H. L. Menckens made frontal assaults on fortresses, they snipe at houses of cards. Allegedly serious intellectuals quibble endlessly over such ridiculous trivialities as the artistic merit versus the political implications of a mural on the wall of a rural post office. In the meantime, the public is lulled into a perilous somnolence, spoon-fed pap and palpable untruths, many of which are turned out by special-interest and pressure groups and well-organized propaganda machines.

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It is hardly surprising that the public mind is dulled and forced into a narrow mold which allows no room for consideration of the day's important issues. Let a semiliterate disc jockey's contract be terminated—for however valid the reason—and his former employers are promptly deluged by furious letters, telegrams and telephone calls expressing protest at the "injustice" and

"persecution." On the other hand, if a pressure group of dubious motive forces the resignation of a distinguished public servant, there are very few protests from the citizenry.

If a motion-picture fan magazine casts aspersions on the dramatic talents of some glandular starlet, the result is instant, widespread reaction from a partisan public. But when a vital piece of legislation is pending before a state legislature or the United States Congress, the matter is usually ignored by the overwhelming majority of citizens. It remains for self-seeking pressure groups and professional lobbyists to inform the lawmakers of the public's attitudes and opinions on the bill in question. The stagnant waters of indifference and apathy are deep.